

for removing smudges and speckles, the ability to correct skewed scans, and the ability to process documents in landscape and portrait format depending on the text formatting, irrespective of how the document is placed in the scanner.

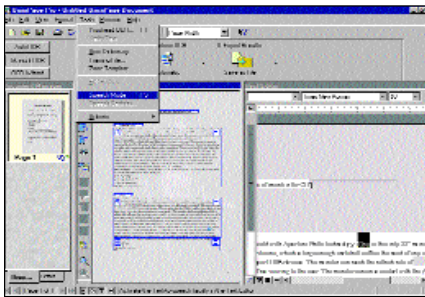
Ease of Use: Here we observed whether the icons had descriptive imagery or captions explaining their function, menu navigation (grouping of features, menu structure and intuitive placement of important features), presence of wizards to guide you through the OCR functions, and help and documentation.

Value for money: This is a factor of the performance and features offered by the OCR package as compared to its price. The greater the performance and features and the lower the price, the higher will be the value for money offered. We computed this value by dividing the sum of an OCR software's performance and features scores by its price.

How they fared Features

OCR-ing large volumes of prints can become a nightmare, but most good packages offer time and effort saving features.

ABBYY FineReader 6.0 CE supports an impressive 122 languages. Sadly though, Indian languages are not included! It also has a table recognition feature and retains the table layout when it saves the document as a Word file—a useful feature if you are OCR-ing balance sheets, *challans*, reports, etc. It also has support for scheduling and batch processing.



OmniPage Pro is the only OCR software with Text-to-Speech facility

The only other software to have scheduling was OmniPage Pro 11. This software supports 114 languages and can also detect page orientation. However, it does not support auto table detection, which means that you will have to manually format tables in Word documents.

PageGenie Pro is rather meagre on features. It supports only 10 languages,

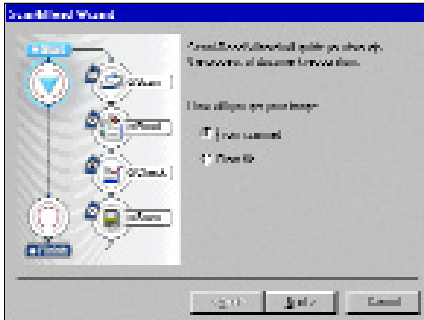
and was also the only software to not have support for recognising characters placed on a coloured background—a big disadvantage if you OCR magazines, brochures or other heavily designed documents.

CuneiForm 2000 did not have support for page orientation detection. This feature makes working with magazine pages rather difficult as it affects the OCR engine's ability to pick up the formatting.

Ease of use

The simplicity of the user interface, presence of productivity enhancing tools such as wizards and auto processing, and sufficiently detailed help and documentation help ease the tedium of OCR-ing large volumes of printed documents.

ABBYY FineReader 6.0 CE and Readiris Pro 7 have the best menu navigation and structure. Both have well defined sub-menus and present a very intuitive interface. A wizard pops up on loading the software. Though FineReader 6.0 CE has a more sophisticated look and feel to its wizard, the functionality is similar to the other software in this comparison. The help and documentation provided with



Wizards in FineReader make OCR-ing a breeze

both software is also pretty good.

CuneiForm 2000, on the other hand, at first glance presents you with only three tabs: File, View and Help. The rest of the menu items are visible only after the page is scanned—this is quite irritating after a few attempts. It also didn't have any online help.

PageGenie Pro 4.0 was the only software here to have poor wizard functionality. It also lagged behind the others in the bundled help and documentation.

Performance

Converting those different kinds of documents, bills, receipts, and newspaper/magazine cuttings into an editable and searchable digital format can be rather frustrat-

Hands free Scanning

Tired of manually feeding in paper and scanning? An Automatic Document Feeder would be the right choice if you need to do batch processing. All you have to do is feed the necessary text documents in the tray and the Automatic Document Feeder will handle the rest.



ing if in the end the OCR software picks up junk and garbled text.

Inkjet printout: We scanned a plain text document with basic formatting such as a drop caps, bold, italics, underline, indents, Web links, superscript and subscript styles. The text used three fonts—Times New Roman, Arial and Garamond. The font size used for the e-mail and Web links was 8 and 10 points respectively, to make character recognition difficult for the OCR engines.

An inkjet printout at high quality is not too much trouble for an OCR software, as it is usually very clean, with few smudges. You should expect nothing less than 99 per cent accuracy from your OCR package and a score of 4 out of 5 for formatting. Also, there should be little or no junk characters in the OCR'd documents.

All software except PageGenie logged high scores for accuracy (ranging between 97 and 99 per cent). OmniPage Pro 11 was particularly impressive, logging 99.29 per cent accuracy—the scanned document had only a couple of spelling mistakes. Plus it was the only software to retain e-mail and Web links, which were underlined and used coloured fonts, and were also clickable when saved as a Word document.

Close on its heels was ABBYY FineReader 6.0 CE, with an accuracy score of 99.05 per cent. This software, along with Readiris Pro 7, were the only two that were able to show drop caps precisely while retaining the original document layout (both scored a brilliant 4.26 out of 5).

The lowest score was of PageGenie Pro 4.0 at 92.92 per cent accuracy, which means that you will have to spend a fair amount of time correcting the scanned document. It picked up the drop caps, but displayed it as a bold font separately and wasn't able to retain the layout. PageGenie Pro 4.0 was unable to